

Cult.fit: Building India's Fitness Habit at Scale

1. Executive Summary

Cult.fit (legally Curefit Healthcare Pvt. Ltd., commonly "Curefit") is Bengaluru-based India's largest branded fitness and wellness platform. Founded in 2016 by Mukesh Bansal and Ankit Nagori (both Flipkart alumni), the company set out to fix a structurally broken market: India's fitness industry was, and largely still is, highly fragmented, low-trust, and dominated by unbranded local gyms with poor retention.

Nearly a decade later, Cult.fit operates a network of over 700 fitness centers across 75+ cities, has narrowed losses while scaling revenue past ₹1,700 crore (FY26 run-rate), turned EBITDA-positive in Q4 FY26, and is preparing for a public listing on Indian exchanges. Its journey from a four-vertical "super-app" (Cult, Eat.fit, Mind.fit, Care.fit) to a focused, fitness-first platform which is a useful lesson in strategic narrowing: knowing when to stop diversifying and double down on the one business that actually works.

2. Company Background

Founded	2016, as Cure.fit
Founders	Mukesh Bansal, Ankit Nagori (Rishabh Telang also credited as co-founder)
Headquarters	Bengaluru, India
Current CEO	Naresh Krishnaswamy
Total funding raised	~\$660–714M across 16+ rounds
Key investors	Temasek, Zomato (Eternal), Tata Digital, Accel, Kalaari Capital, Chiratae Ventures, South Park Commons
Footprint	700+ centers, 75+ cities (India)

Status	Preparing for an IPO (~₹2,500 crore issue size reported), investment bankers engaged

The founders had prior credibility: Bansal built and sold Myntra to Flipkart; Nagori was Flipkart's Chief Product Officer. That pedigree helped Cure.fit raise capital quickly and recruit talent in a market still skeptical of fitness-as-a-business.

3. The Original Strategy: A Wellness Super-App

Cure.fit launched with four verticals under one brand umbrella:

- **Cult.fit** — group fitness classes (no-equipment, trainer-led workouts) and gyms
- **Eat.fit** — healthy meal delivery
- **Mind.fit** — yoga, meditation, mental wellness
- **Care.fit** — primary healthcare, diagnostics, chronic disease management (e.g., diabetes)

The thesis: bundle physical fitness, food, mind, and healthcare into a single subscription ecosystem, cross-selling users across verticals and building a moat through data and habit formation.

This is the classic "super-app" hypothesis the same logic Gojek, Grab, and Paytm pursued. In practice, it proved hard to execute for wellness, because each vertical had a different unit economics profile, a different customer acquisition motion, and different operational complexity (delivery logistics for Eat.fit vs. real-estate-heavy gym rollouts for Cult).

4. Strategic Pivot: From Super-App to Focused Platform

Over time, the company made a deliberate and instructive decision to prune:

- **Eat.fit was spun off** in 2020 into a separate company (later evolving into Curefoods, a cloud-kitchen business under co-founder Ankit Nagori, who exited Curefit to run it).
- **Care.fit was largely wound down** - healthcare delivery required a different regulatory, clinical, and trust infrastructure than fitness.
- **Mind.fit was absorbed** into the core Cult.fit product as a yoga/meditation feature rather than a standalone brand.
- **Cult.fit became the flagship and, effectively, the whole company.**

This is a strong illustration of a general principle: **diversification that doesn't share a genuine operational or acquisition moat with the core business becomes a drag, not a flywheel**. Cure.fit's food and healthcare businesses required different supply chains, different regulatory relationships, and different trust signals than group fitness. Retreating to the strongest business Cult let the company concentrate capital and management attention where it already had a defensible position.

5. Business Model

Cult.fit's revenue today comes primarily from two streams:

1. **Fitness subscriptions (~73% of revenue)** — led by **Cultpass**, a pan-India membership that gives access to any Cult.fit center nationwide, plus Cult.fit-owned gyms, group classes (HRX, dance, strength formats), and platform/digital fitness content. This segment grew ~33% year-on-year to ₹889 crore in FY25.
2. **Product sales (~27% of revenue)** — sportswear and fitness gear sold under Cult's own brand, growing ~27% YoY to ₹326 crore in FY25.

Key model choice – asset-light-ish, franchise-and-own hybrid: Cult.fit operates a mix of company-owned centers and partner gyms accessible through Cultpass, letting it scale geographic coverage faster than a pure company-owned rollout would allow, while still controlling the flagship "Cult" experience at its own centers.

Pricing tiering: Cult.fit is pushing a lower-priced format, **Cult Neo**, to penetrate price-sensitive tier-2/tier-3 cities a classic "good-better-best" tiering strategy aimed at expanding the addressable market beyond premium metro users.

6. The Retention Playbook

India's fitness market has structural headwinds that make Cult.fit's positioning notable:

- The organized/branded gym segment is tiny, most of India's 200,000+ gyms are unbranded, inconsistent, and low-trust.
- Fitness penetration is roughly **0.6%** of the population, versus ~22% in the US — meaning most of the addressable growth is about *creating* the habit, not stealing it from a competitor.
- Industry-wide, most users who do start a fitness routine drop off within three to six months.

Cult.fit's counter-strategy is built around **retention as the core product**, not just acquisition:

- **Standardization** — Cultpass guarantees a consistent format and quality bar across hundreds of centers nationwide, which builds trust that unbranded local gyms can't match.
- **Gamification & community** — leaderboards, streaks, and group-class formats designed to make showing up social rather than solitary.
- **Hybrid flexibility** — users can move between in-center classes, gym access, and at-home digital workouts depending on schedule and mood, reducing the "all or nothing" drop-off risk.
- **Habit-building nudges** — data-driven, behavioral micro-interventions (reminders, streak protection, personalized recommendations) aimed at making fitness a low-friction routine rather than a willpower exercise.

The strategic bet here is that in an under-penetrated, low-loyalty market, **the company that solves the churn problem, not just the acquisition problem and wins disproportionate long-term value**, because customer lifetime value compounds while CAC stays roughly flat.

7. Financial Trajectory

Fiscal Year	Operating Revenue	Net Loss	Notes
FY21	₹294.9 Cr (~₹161 Cr from operations)	—	Pandemic-hit, revenue fell ~67% YoY
FY23	₹693.7 Cr	₹625.5 Cr	Recovery phase
FY24	₹926.6 Cr	₹888.5 Cr	Loss widened due to cash burn/expansion
FY25	₹1,215.5 Cr (+31% YoY)	₹481 Cr (loss narrowed ~10%)	IPO prep phase
FY26 (reported)	>₹1,700 Cr (+40% YoY)	EBITDA-positive in Q4 FY26	First profitable quarter on EBITDA basis

Read on the numbers: Cult.fit's trajectory is a textbook "grow first, profitability later" venture-backed story, but the FY25→FY26 shift steep revenue growth *combined with* a swing to EBITDA-positive is the inflection point that public-market investors look for before an IPO. It signals the unit economics of the core Cultpass business are now sound at scale, even if company-wide net losses (post interest, depreciation, and amortization from a decade of expansion and 14 acquisitions) persist.

Critics, however, note that Cult.fit's growth has historically leaned heavily on inorganic expansion (having acquired 14 companies across nine sectors) and continued heavy funding rather than demonstrated pricing

power or exceptional brand loyalty a fair caution for anyone evaluating the IPO thesis rather than just the growth headline.

8. Competitive Landscape

Cult.fit competes across a fragmented set of players with different models:

- **Unbranded local gyms** — the largest segment by volume, low price, low consistency (Cult's core competitive target to convert)
- **HealthifyMe, GOQii, Growfitter** — digital-first health/fitness tracking and coaching apps
- **Wellhub (formerly Gympass)** — corporate wellness aggregator model, a more direct international analog
- **MyFitnessPal, Fitpass** — app-based fitness/nutrition tracking

Cult.fit's differentiation isn't really against these digital players — it's against the *status quo of no organized alternative at all*. Its moat is the physical network (hundreds of standardized centers) combined with the software layer (Cultpass, content, community features) — a combination that's expensive and slow for a pure digital player to replicate, and hard for a single unbranded gym to match.

9. Strategic Outlook

Looking forward, Cult.fit's stated priorities are:

1. **Geographic expansion** — from 75+ cities to 100 cities over the next five to six years, led by the lower-cost **Cult Neo** format to unlock price-sensitive segments.
 2. **Deeper penetration in existing markets** rather than pure new-city land grab.
 3. **IPO on Indian exchanges** — with Goldman Sachs, Morgan Stanley, Jefferies, Axis Capital, and JM Financial reportedly engaged as bankers for an issue sized around ₹2,500 crore.
 4. **Continued brand-led growth** — leadership has explicitly framed brand loyalty as an *outcome* of product design and delivery consistency, not a separate marketing initiative, suggesting retention economics will remain the central strategic lever rather than aggressive discount-led acquisition.
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10. Key Discussion Questions

1. What made Cure.fit's original four-vertical "super-app" strategy attractive on paper, and why did it prove hard to execute? Which of the four verticals shared the most operational and acquisition synergy with Cult, and which shared the least?

2. Cult.fit chose to standardize the *experience* (via Cultpass) rather than compete purely on price. In a market where 99%+ of the population isn't yet exercising, is a retention-first strategy the right early bet, or should the company have prioritized raw acquisition/penetration first?
3. Evaluate Cult.fit's FY25–FY26 financials. Is the shift to EBITDA-positive in Q4 FY26 a genuine inflection point, or a pre-IPO optimization? What additional data would you want before accepting the IPO thesis?
4. Cult.fit grew partly through 14 acquisitions across nine sectors. What are the risks of an acquisition-heavy growth strategy for a company that ultimately narrowed back to a single core vertical?
5. How does Cult.fit's asset-light-ish, hybrid owned/partner-gym network compare as a scaling strategy to a pure company-owned rollout (higher control, slower scale) or a pure marketplace/aggregator model like Wellhub (faster scale, less control over experience)?

Sources: Business Standard, Entracker, Inc42, Tracxn, PitchBook (data as of July 2026). Financial figures are drawn from company RoC filings and press reporting; treat pre-IPO figures as subject to revision in final prospectus documents.